

L^AT_EX for Elegant Humanities Handouts in Conferences and Classrooms

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Abstract

L^AT_EX has been popular throughout the mathematical and physical sciences for decades. L^AT_EX’s utility for scholars in humanities disciplines, however, tends to be overlooked. In this tutorial, I introduce the use of L^AT_EX for a common task in humanities scholarship, namely, typesetting texts with unusual line length and other organizational needs, such as poetry and translations. The specific example is preparing a handout for a historical conference or class presentation with excerpts of ancient Greek and parallel English translations. Additionally, I provide some general recommendations for learning and employing L^AT_EX across the humanities disciplines. I aim to inspire colleagues in religious, historical, philosophical, and related areas to think of L^AT_EX as having a wide range of professional applications even inside these scholarly fields in which L^AT_EX is not widespread.

1 Introduction

The world’s best established software system for typesetting and document formatting, L^AT_EX has been popular throughout mathematical and physical sciences for decades. The utility of L^AT_EX for humanities disciplines, however, tends to be overlooked. L^AT_EX can be used for typesetting in most instances in which a scholar of humanities needs to present materials. Whether one works in history, philosophy, literature, or some other discipline in which L^AT_EX is not usually employed, L^AT_EX is nevertheless worth the investment of time to learn.

Granted, in disciplines outside the mathematical and physical sciences, such as my own area of historical theology (technically, divinities rather than humanities), editors expect us to prepare our materials for publications with bug-for-bug compatibility with Microsoft Word for back-and-forth markup. In practice, this expectation requires us to use word processors, such as LibreOffice Writer. A word processor presents material in a What You See Is What You Get (WYSIWYG, “whizzy-wig”) style. While one writes, one is simultaneously thinking about and working on formatting.

In a typesetting language, such as L^AT_EX (or ConT_EXt or Typst, either of which a scholar might also choose for various reasons), one is only concerned about the structure of what one is writing. One declares that specific characters will be in certain categories of writing ‘things’ (heading, paragraph,

footnote, accent type, typeface, and so on), and one allows the program to compile one’s writing as ‘code’ into a tidy final document — every time. Preparing a *curriculum vitae*, conference handout, or other document with unusual typesetting requirements becomes about the writing itself rather than the formatting.

To learn L^AT_EX as a scholar outside the disciplines in which L^AT_EX is the norm, I recommend working through one of two community-built, libre guidebooks. The first, which I used to learn L^AT_EX, is *The Not So Short Introduction to L^AT_EX* (github.com/oetiker/lshort). The second, which a colleague of mine recommends, is *Modern L^AT_EX* (github.com/mrkline/modern-latex). Either guidebook may be used to begin to learn how to typeset cover letters, ancient languages, and other materials that are relevant across the humanities — without the front-loading of mathematics and physical sciences that one finds in other general introductions.

To show how thinking about digital typesetting in terms of document structure rather than final format can be of practical use in the humanities, here I present a tutorial in which I introduce the use of L^AT_EX for a common task in humanities scholarship, namely, typesetting texts with unusual line length and other organizational needs. The thought experiment is that of determining how to prepare a handout for a historical conference or class presentation with perfectly organized excerpts of a Byzantine Greek text and an original English translation in parallel.

2 Simplest parallel text in L^AT_EX

There are many ways to set parallel text in L^AT_EX. The simplest is to use the community package called `parallel`, which is included in T_EX Live, MiK_T_EX, and other L^AT_EX distributions. For full documentation, visit <https://ctan.org/pkg/parallel>.

To start using `parallel` in any L^AT_EX document, include the following in the preamble:

```
\usepackage{parallel}
```

For example, here is an abbreviation of the preamble to the Beamer file for my talk at T_EX Users Group 2026 (github.com/historical-theology/latex-talks/) with only the most important entries, including `parallel`:

```
\documentclass[aspectratio=169]{beamer}
\usetheme{Goettingen}
```

```
\usepackage{parallel}
```

```
\title{\LaTeX\ for Elegant Humanities Handouts
  \ in Conferences and Classrooms }
\author{Corey Stephan, Ph.D.}
```

```
\begin{document}
```

This is the basic format for parallel text set with the package `parallel`:

```
\begin{Parallel}{<left space>}{<right space>}
\ParallelLText{<left text row 1>}
\ParallelRText{<right text row 1>}
\ParallelPar
\ParallelLText{<left text row 2>}
[and so on]
\end{Parallel}
```

I (a theologian) might typeset the opening words of the Christian prayer *Ave Maria* in their traditional Latin with parallel English like so:

```
\begin{Parallel}{0em}{0em}
\ParallelLText{Ave Maria,}
\ParallelRText{Hail Mary,}
\ParallelPar
\ParallelLText{gratia plena \ldots}
\ParallelRText{full of grace \ldots}
\ParallelPar
\end{Parallel}
```

Here is the result:

Ave Maria,	Hail Mary,
gratia plena ...	full of grace ...

3 Advanced parallel text in $\LaTeX$

For advanced scholarly setting of parallel text in $\LaTeX$, especially long-form (e.g. a critical edition with accompanying translation), one ought to learn the two interconnected and frequently updated community packages `reledpar` (for parallel typesetting specifically) and `reledmac` (for typesetting academic editions in general), which are bundled with $\TeX$ Live and other $\LaTeX$ distributions.

`reledpar` and `reledmac` are purpose-built for long-form academic parallel texts. These two packages are meant to replace older methods of academic parallel text preparation in $\LaTeX$ that one might find in Web searches. For full documentation, visit ctan.org/pkg/reledpar and ctan.org/pkg/reledmac.

4 Setting non-Latin characters in $\LaTeX$

The most important packages for handling text outside Latin alphabets are `babel` and `polyglossia`, which are included in $\TeX$ Live and other $\LaTeX$ distributions. Although it is possible to convert a project from one of these metapackages to the other, a scholar ought to invest the time to choose carefully between either of these two at the start of a long-form project.

4.1 `babel` vs. `polyglossia`

In *The $\LaTeX$ Companion: 3rd Edition* (Addison-Wesley, 2023), Frank Mittelbach and Ulrike Fischer suggest that despite the fact that `babel` is older than

`polyglossia`, `babel` generally is preferable: “Unless you are in a special situation where a language or script is notably better supported by `polyglossia`, the recommendation is to use `babel` with all engines” (entry 13.7.2, “Polyglossia”). Since `babel` technically supports the same languages as `polyglossia`, a situation in which one would need `polyglossia` over `babel` will be rare. Yet, a scholar working with ancient languages might have such a rare situation.

In (old) Web forum discussions, one might read that `babel` will work better with $\text{Lua}\LaTeX$, whereas `polyglossia` will work better with $\text{Xe}\LaTeX$. In 2026, however, one may choose either of the two mainline $\LaTeX$ engines that are built with full Unicode support, that is, $\text{Xe}\LaTeX$ or $\text{Lua}\LaTeX$, for `babel` or `polyglossia`. Results might vary, however, depending on the specifics of a given project.

To make an informed choice against a specific set of requirements for a given academic undertaking, one should explore each package’s documentation at ctan.org/pkg/babel and ctan.org/pkg/polyglossia.

To learn `babel`, I recommend Chapter 13: “Localizing documents” in *The $\LaTeX$ Companion: 3rd Edition* by Mittelbach and Fischer, which succinctly introduces localization in $\LaTeX$ via `babel` in a practical, didactic (teaching) style.

To learn `polyglossia`, I recommend the package’s official documentation in CTAN.

5 Starting a project with `polyglossia`

Here, I will model `polyglossia`, which is what I happen to be familiar with using for polytonic (ancient and Byzantine) Greek.

First, include the package in the preamble:

```
\usepackage{polyglossia}
```

Then, after the beginning of the document but before actual type, declare the languages and their variants. For example, here is this .tex file’s `polyglossia` declarations:

```
\begin{document}
\setdefaultlanguage{english}
\setotherlanguage[variant=ancient]{greek}
```

One is able to use one of the ‘other’ declared languages (in this case, ancient Greek) by toggling it when needed.

A declared foreign or ancient language may be toggled for a long excerpt like so:

```
\begin{greek}
<greek text>
...
\end{greek}
```

For example, this is how one could set the famous opening verse of John’s Gospel:

```
\begin{greek}
έν αρχῇ ἦν ὁ λόγος, \\\
καὶ ὁ λόγος ἦν πρὸς τὸν θεόν, \\\
καὶ θεὸς ἦν ὁ λόγος. \\\
\end{greek}
```

Here is the clean result:

έν αρχῇ ἦν ὁ λόγος,
καὶ ὁ λόγος ἦν πρὸς τὸν θεόν,
καὶ θεὸς ἦν ὁ λόγος.

For another example, here are the first two lines of Homer's *The Iliad*:

```
\begin{greek}
μῆνιν ἄειδε θεὰ Πηληϊάδεω Ἀχιλῆος \\\
οὐλομένην, ἣ μυρὶ' Ἀχαιοῖς ἄλγε' ἔθηκε \ldots
\end{greek}
```

The result is equally clean to that of John 1:1, even for these particular words of Homer with their more complicated accent and breathing marks:

μῆνιν ἄειδε θεὰ Πηληϊάδεω Ἀχιλῆος
οὐλομένην, ἣ μυρὶ' Ἀχαιοῖς ἄλγε' ἔθηκε ...

A declared language may be toggled for a single word or line (rather than a series of verses or lines) in this way:

```
\text<language><{<text in language>}
```

This mid-line toggling style be used to insert a key-word in that declared language, e.g. ὁ λόγος (produced with `\textgreek{ὁ λόγος}`), inside running prose in another language, such as the document's primary one.

6 Combining parallel and polyglossia

The simplest way of setting multilingual text in parallel is with `parallel`, as was shown in section (2). Since `parallel` can be tedious to organize for more than a stanza/paragraph or two, I remind the reader of `reledpar` and `reledmac` for longer and/or more complicated parallel text displays, as I recommended in section (3).

Here is an example of `parallel` and `polyglossia` working in combination to display my own translation from the opening chapter of my recently published historical monograph *Maximus the Confessor's Thomistic Legacy* (Pontifical Institute of Mediaeval Studies: Toronto, 2026):

```
\begin{Parallel}{0mm}{0mm}
\textgreek{\ParallelLText{Νῦν συγχορεύεις ἀληθῶς}}
\ParallelRText{Now, truly, you celebrate together}
\ParallelPar
\textgreek{\ParallelLText{σὺν τοῖς λοιποῖς θεολόγοις}}
\ParallelRText{with the rest of the theologians}
[and so on]
\end{Parallel}
```

For a conference or classroom handout, the result might look like this:

“Canon in Honor of Thomas Aquinas,” Ode ³¹
Translated by Corey Stephan, Ph.D.

Νῦν συγχορεύεις ἀληθῶς
σὺν τοῖς λοιποῖς θεολόγοις
καὶ τοῖς ἄλλοις θεολήτοις ἀνδράσι,
περὶ τὸν θρόνον Χριστοῦ
τὸν ἱερὸν ἐξῆδοντες
καὶ τρισάγιον ὕμνον
σὺν τοῖς ἁγίαις δυνάμεσιν.

Ἐνθα πατέρων ὁ χορὸς
καὶ ἱερῶν θεολόγων
ὡς ὑψόνους καὶ λεπτοῦς θεολόγους
κατεσκήνωσας, Θωμά,
σὺν τούτοις ἀλιζόμενος,
θεολογῶν ἀπαύστως
τριῶδα, πάτερ, τὴν ἁκτιστον.

Now, truly, you celebrate together
with the rest of the theologians
and the other divinely inspired men
around the throne of Christ,
singing the sacred
and Thrice-Holy Hymn
with the holy powers.

Where there is the chorus of Fathers
and holy theologians,
as a high-minded and subtle theologian
you do abide, Thomas,
dwelling with them,
unceasingly theologizing,
O Father, about the Uncreated Trinity.

7 Other L^AT_EX tools for scholars of humanities

There are many L^AT_EX tools that can assist work across the humanities disciplines. Here is a succinct, curated list of the most broadly applicable:

- BIBL^AT_EX offers a comprehensive citation and bibliography management system that is capable of being interlinked with a variety of citation managers—notably, for academic research, Zotero and JabRef.

BIBL^AT_EX is built into T_EX Live and other L^AT_EX distributions.

- The free and open source graphical software application TeXstudio (texstudio.org) offers a L^AT_EX -specific writing environment with comfortable features like intuitive autocompletion of L^AT_EX commands.

L^AT_EX may be written in any plain text editor, but a designated environment improves efficiency and helps avoid code errors.

TeXstudio is included in the official software repositories of most libre Unix-like operating systems (GNU/Linux and BSD).

- By running search queries in CTAN, one may find community-built packages for many individual languages that are of relevance for historical or other academic research, e.g. `aramaic-serto` for the ancient Middle-Eastern language Syriac (Aramaic).
- `microtype` offers many small adjustments to type, such as improved automatic justification and hyphenation.

This article is a working example of the `microtype` package in-use.

³¹ The Greek text is from Raffaele Cantarella, ed., “Canone greco inedito di Giuseppe vescovo di Methone in onore di San Tommaso d’Aquino,” *Archivum Fratrum Praedicatorum* 12 (1934): 145–85, at 155–58.

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